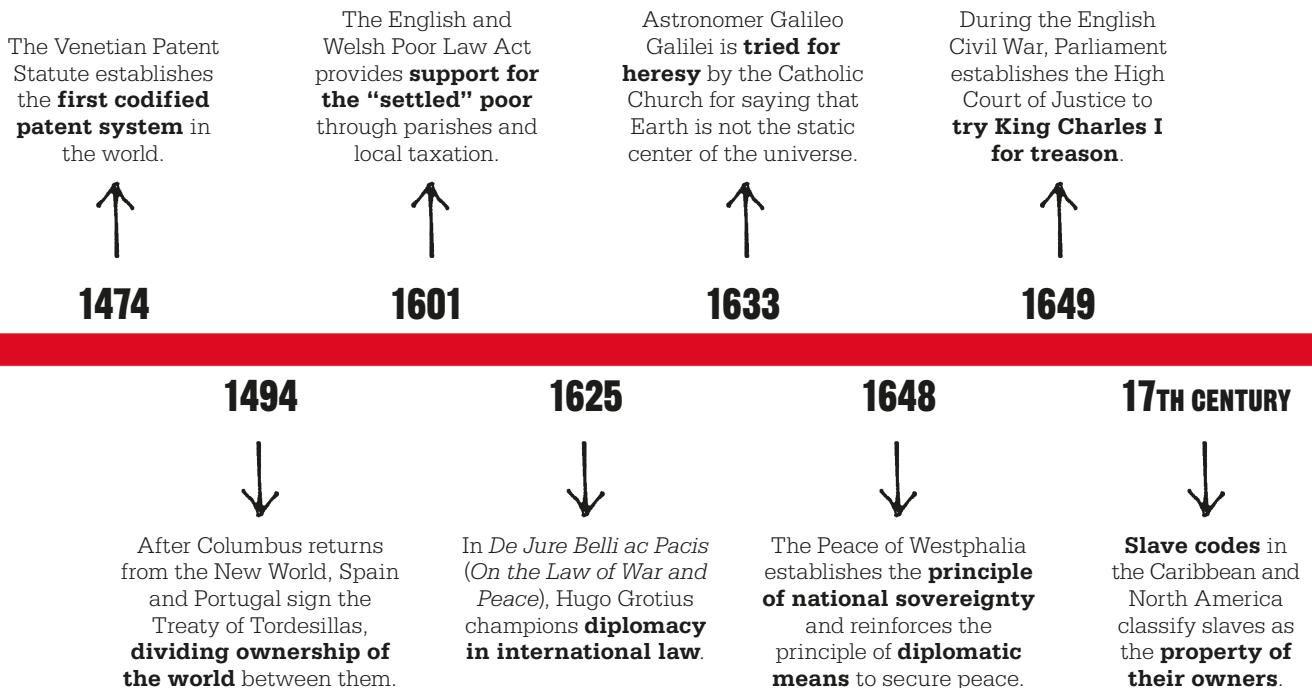




At the end of the 15th century, enormous cultural and political changes started to take effect in Europe, ushering in the age known as the Renaissance. Nation-states began to assert their independence and found prosperity through trade and empire building. The Catholic Church's authority was challenged as these changes shifted the emphasis from religion to natural laws inherent in humans.

One of the major mercantile powers to emerge was the Republic of Venice, which introduced commercial laws, such as the Patent Statute, to protect the interests of its traders. Spain and Portugal were the most ambitious powers, seeking routes across the Atlantic to Asian markets as an alternative to the overland Silk

Road. After Christopher Columbus stumbled across the Americas on his voyages of discovery, the two Iberian states negotiated a deal, the Treaty of Tordesillas, in which they effectively divided the world into two hemispheres, awarding Spain the lands to the west and Portugal those to the east. These claims were indicative of the prevalent attitude that the world was there to be "discovered"—and conquered and exploited—by the new European trading nations. The Protestant Reformation of the 16th century was a further challenge to the authority of the Church.

International order

Trading and territorial disputes led to battles between the countries vying for dominance, and in the 17th century, steps were taken to

establish an international rule of law. In 1625, Dutch scholar Hugo Grotius wrote the treatise *On the Law of War and Peace*, which championed human reasoning and cooperation in international affairs. This was then played out in 1648 in the Peace of Westphalia, which brought an end to the Thirty Years' War and established a precedent for diplomatic negotiations to protect national sovereignty. A century later, the basis for truly international law was laid by Swiss diplomat Emmerich de Vattel in *The Law of Nations*.

The Americas and parts of Africa and Asia soon became colonies of European empires, providing seemingly endless resources. But it was not only goods that were being traded. To provide labor in the colonies